Ethical Prism: Virtue Ethics

Virtue Ethics

Scenario: Students increasingly use large language models like ChatGPT to complete school assignments. Consequently, grades improve, but students report spending less time thinking, struggling with hard topics, or engaging deeply with the material.

Honesty

Truthfulness in academic work is fundamental to education. When students submit AI-generated work and pass it off as their own, they may compromise this core virtue. This matters because being a an honest person is essential to establishing justified trust with others..

Perseverance

Willingness to struggle with difficult material is how one develops perseverance and resilience. Consequently, taking AI shortcuts may make one more impatient (or lazy) and less inclined to be curious.

Intellectual Humility

Recognizing the limits of one’s knowledge, or having humility, allows one to grow intellectually. When students convince themselves they know something they had to turn to AI for, they can develop false confidence in their abilities, even become arrogant.

Virtue Ethics

In sum, virtue ethics doesn’t just ask not only what students do with AI, but who they become through repeated actions with it. The moral issue is how AI impacts their character.

The Limitations of Moral Principles

Traditional View

Ethics traditionally focuses on moral principles and universal rules, such as utilitarian emphasis on promoting the greatest good or Kant’s requirement to treat everyone with dignity.

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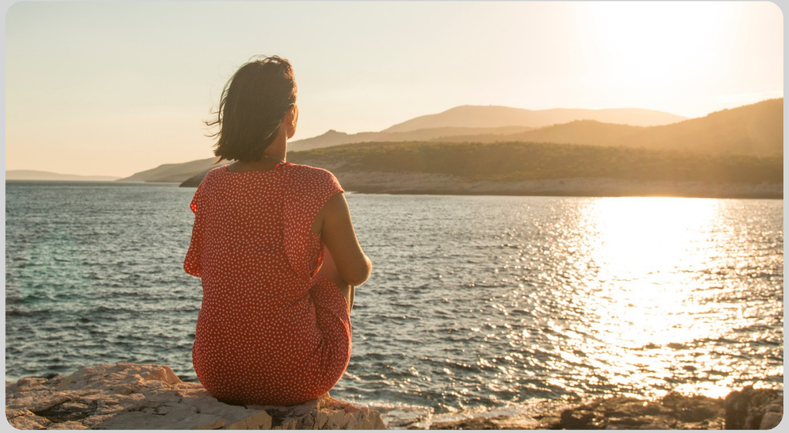
Critique

Critics argue that the emphasis on following moral principles can lead to thoughtless rule-following that neglects deeper aspects of moral life—crucially, the importance of moral character and personal development.

Introducing Virtue Ethics

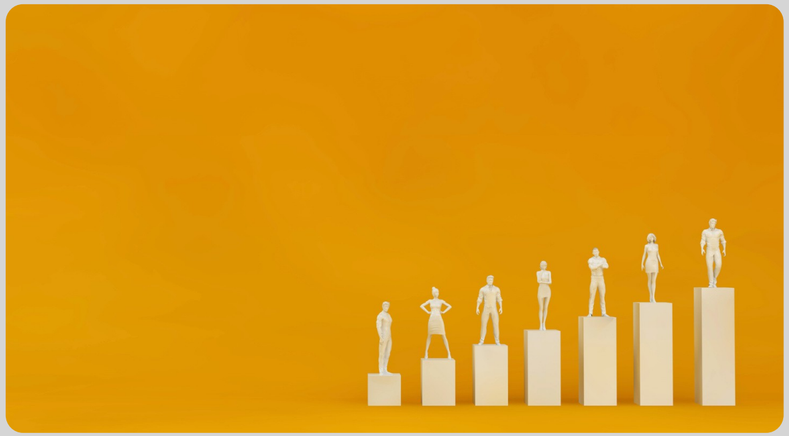
Focus on Character

Virtue ethics shifts the focus from actions to the person performing them, emphasizing character development over rule-following.



Ideals and Potential

It encourages striving towards ideals that allow for the full development of our humanity, discovered through thoughtful reflection.



Virtues as Traits

Virtues are attitudes, dispositions, or character traits that enable us to pursue these ideals and develop our potential.

Examples of Virtues

Honesty

Courage

Compassion

Integrity

Other examples mentioned in the article include generosity, fidelity, fairness, self-control, and prudence.

Developing Virtues

Learning

Acquire knowledge about virtues and their importance through experiential learning—not merely reading about ethics.

Practice

Consistently apply virtues in daily life to acquire them. Practice builds character.

Habit Formation

Virtues become characteristic traits—dispositions we're inclined to follow .

As Aristotle suggested, character can be improved through self-discipline or corrupted by self-indulgence. Like physical abilities, virtues develop through consistent practice.

Virtues as Habits

Characteristic Traits

Once acquired, virtues become defining features of a person’s character.

Consistent Behavior

A virtuous person tends to act in accordance with their virtues across various situations.

Praiseworthy

Virtuous individuals are inclined to act in ways that others find worthy of moral praise.

The Role of Community

Individual

Family

Local Community

Broader Society

Virtue ethics emphasizes the importance of community in character development. Our personalities and virtues are shaped by the values, traits, and role models present in our families, schools, and broader social circles.

Beyond Rules: The Moral Life

Traditional View

Following moral rules and applying them to specific situations.

Virtue Ethics View

Determining the kind of people we should be and developing character within our communities and ourselves.

Virtue ethics encourages a more holistic approach to morality, focusing on personal growth and community development alongside ethical decision-making.